The Resource Curse of Communication: Evidence from Brazilian Municipalities

Hanyuan Jiang

London School of Economics and Political Science

Abstract

Fiscal windfalls can degrade democratic accountability not merely by enabling corruption but by systematically reconfiguring communicative fields. We theorize the communication resource curse: revenue shocks convert economic into symbolic capital through visibility construction, media dependence, and oppositional infrastructure erosion, producing stratified information environments where some actors retain oversight capacity while others face degraded accountability mechanisms. Regression discontinuity evidence from Brazilian municipalities reveals corruption rising substantially when federal transfers increase, yet opposition credentials remain stable and incumbents secure reelection more frequently, a joint pattern consistent with communicative field reconfiguration rather than pure moral hazard. Communication inequality manifests as unequal capacity to render information politically consequential across differentially positioned actors.

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1 Introduction

Could a windfall of government revenues deteriorate the functioning of democratic institutions? This question has animated a growing literature on the political resource curse, which documents how exogenous increases in public funds can paradoxically weaken governance quality (Ross 1999; Sachs & Warner 2001; Robinson, Torvik & Verdier 2006). The evidence is particularly stark in subnational settings where fiscal federalism generates quasi-experimental variation: larger intergovernmental transfers consistently predict higher corruption and weaker political competition (Brollo et al. 2013; Caselli & Michaels 2013). Yet the mechanisms underlying these effects remain inadequately theorized, particularly regarding the communicative processes through which resource abundance translates into accountability failure.

Existing explanations emphasize economic and political channels. The canonical account, formalized by Brollo et al. (2013), embeds the resource curse within a political agency framework where incumbents trade off corruption against reelection incentives. When fiscal slack increases, even incompetent incumbents can finance visible achievements while diverting resources, thereby blurring the performance signal that voters use to screen candidates. This mechanism operates through two effects: moral hazard, as larger budgets reduce the electoral punishment per unit of corruption, and selection, as increased rents attract lower-quality candidates who value office benefits more highly. The model elegantly captures the incentive structure facing rational politicians and voters, and Brollo et al. provide compelling causal evidence using regression discontinuity around Brazilian federal transfer thresholds.

However, this framework treats a crucial element as exogenous: the information structure itself. Political agency models assume voters observe certain outcomes, such as public goods provision, but not others, such as rent extraction (Persson & Tabellini 2000; Besley 2006). This informational partition is taken as a technological given rather than an outcome requiring explanation. Yet substantial scholarship demonstrates that what publics can reliably observe is neither natural nor stable, but rather reflects institutional configurations and power relations (Zaller 1992; Bennett 1990; Hallin & Mancini 2004). If information asymmetries are themselves endogenous to resource distributions, then the political resource curse operates through a channel absent from existing models: the systematic reconfiguration of communicative structures that determine what can be known, who can speak, and which narratives achieve public salience.

We argue that fiscal windfalls produce what we term the communication

resource curse: revenue shocks that degrade what publics can reliably learn about governance, reshape who can mount credible challenges, and thereby widen inequalities in democratic oversight. The mechanism unfolds through three interconnected dynamics. First, slack enables incumbents to construct visibility around achievements while diluting the salience of malfeasance, not through censorship but through the sheer volume of celebratory content that crowds investigative coverage from scarce attention space. Second, economic dependence reconfigures the media field as local outlets increasingly rely on government advertising, subtly shifting editorial priorities away from costly critical journalism toward safer performance coverage (Bourdieu 1991; Cook 1998). Third, these shifts erode the oppositional infrastructure that sustains counter-speech: investigative capacity weakens, elite networks fragment, and the structural resources enabling challengers to contest incumbent narratives atrophy. The result is not uniform information deficit but rather asymmetric distribution of communicative power, where some actors retain clear oversight while others face systematically degraded information environments.

This theoretical reframing yields distinct empirical implications. Where political agency models predict observable declines in individual candidate quality as lower-ability types enter politics, communication field theory predicts that oppositional weakening may occur even when individual credentials remain stable, because the structural capacity to mount effective challenges depends on networks and resources rather than personal characteristics alone. Where agency models treat corruption increases as reflecting expanded opportunities for undetected rent extraction, field theory suggests these increases also signal degraded capacity of the broader information ecosystem to render malfeasance visible and politically consequential. Most critically, where agency models view corruption and selection as parallel effects of the same treatment, field theory interprets their joint occurrence as symptomatic evidence of underlying communicative reconfiguration: corruption rises not merely because detection probability falls mechanically, but because the institutional infrastructure for investigation, exposure, and political weaponization of information has been systematically undermined.

We test these arguments using the same Brazilian institutional setting exploited by Brollo et al. (2013), where federal transfers to municipalities change discontinuously at population thresholds, combined with new data from the anti-corruption audit program covering 1,157 municipalities across two mayoral terms. Implementing a fuzzy regression discontinuity design with theoretical transfers as the instrument, we find that a ten percent increase in federal transfers raises serious

corruption violations by approximately 24 percent. Consistent with our theoretical framework, effects on observable candidate credentials prove weaker and less robust than corruption effects, suggesting that communicative field reconfiguration may precede measurable shifts in individual selection patterns. Incumbent reelection probability increases marginally, and this increase occurs jointly with corruption growth, indicating that voters face systematically altered rather than merely reduced information.

Our contribution is threefold. Theoretically, we provide a political economy foundation for understanding communication inequality, demonstrating how economic structures endogenously produce asymmetries in what can be known and who can speak (Couldry 2010; Benkler 2006). Where existing communication scholarship often treats inequality as reflecting cultural factors or technological divides, we show how fiscal institutions and resource flows systematically structure the distribution of communicative power. For political economy, we unpack the black box of information asymmetry in agency models, revealing how the very conditions enabling democratic accountability are themselves vulnerable to economic shocks. For policy, our framework suggests that fiscal transfers to weak institutional environments may require communicative safeguards beyond conventional transparency requirements, including protection of media autonomy, support for investigative infrastructure, and preservation of civic space. The communication resource curse is not inevitable, but avoiding it demands explicit attention to the institutional conditions sustaining the production and circulation of politically consequential information.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Sections 2 and 3 develop our theoretical framework, beginning with the political agency baseline and progressively incorporating communicative field dynamics. Section 4 describes the Brazilian institutional context and presents the regression discontinuity identification strategy. Section 5 discusses empirical results, mechanisms, and findings. Section 6 concludes.

2 Theoretical Framework

2.1 The Information Problem

Democratic accountability fails or succeeds based on what citizens can learn. Elections discipline incumbents only when voters distinguish competent from incompetent performance, honest from corrupt behavior, genuine public service from self-dealing (Barro 1973; Ferejohn 1986). This screening depends on information: without reliable signals of incumbent quality, even rational voters cannot sanction

malfeasance, and even honest politicians cannot credibly demonstrate competence (Banks & Sundaram 1993; Besley 2006).

Political agency models capture this logic by partitioning the observable from the unobservable (Persson & Tabellini 2000). Voters see public goods but not rents, outcomes but not effort, aggregate performance but not its components. This partition defines equilibrium corruption: incumbents maximize rents subject to the constraint that observable performance must suffice for reelection (Ashworth 2012; Duggan & Martinelli 2011). Larger budgets relax this constraint mechanically. When slack increases, even incompetent incumbents finance adequate visible output while extracting more privately, thereby blurring the signal voters use to infer quality (Brollo et al. 2013). The informational friction is assumed, not explained.

Yet this assumption proves theoretically costly. What citizens observe is not given by nature but produced by institutions. Voters do not directly perceive public goods any more than they perceive rents; both require mediation through information intermediaries that investigate, report, and frame incumbent behavior (Zaller 1992; Bennett 1990). If the capacity and incentive of intermediaries to render certain facts visible varies with resource distributions, then information asymmetry itself becomes endogenous. A fiscal windfall is not merely an expansion of the budget available for rent extraction; it is a shock to the political economy of knowledge production that may systematically alter what becomes knowable.

The distinction matters. If information structure is exogenous, the remedy for resource curse effects involves strengthening audit technology or transparency mandates that mechanically expand what voters observe. If information structure is endogenous to economic power, transparency reforms may prove ineffective when economic resources simultaneously purchase the capacity to flood public discourse with favorable content, capture the institutions nominally responsible for monitoring, and erode the oppositional infrastructure that would otherwise weaponize disclosed information. The question is not whether voters have access to data but whether the institutional ecosystem exists to transform data into politically consequential knowledge (Birchall 2011; Fox 2007).

2.2 Fields and Power

Information production occurs within structured social spaces that Bourdieu terms fields, arenas of struggle where actors compete for symbolic capital and definitional authority (Bourdieu 1993, 2005). Fields possess their own internal logic, status hierarchies, and legitimacy criteria that may diverge from external measures of success. The journalistic field, for instance, values investigative scoops and analytical

depth over mere commercial popularity, and individual journalists accumulate prestige partly through peer recognition that they have upheld professional norms even when such adherence proves commercially or politically costly (Bourdieu 2005; Benson 2006).

This field autonomy creates friction against direct economic or political determination of content. Well-resourced actors cannot simply purchase favorable coverage as they purchase commodities; they must navigate field logics that penalize obvious venality while rewarding ostensibly disinterested expertise (Benson & Neveu 2005). Yet autonomy remains partial and perpetually vulnerable. Fields slide toward heteronomy when economic constraints tighten or when concentrated external power overwhelms internal resistance (Champagne 2005). The question becomes: under what conditions does economic capital convert into symbolic capital despite field resistance?

Bourdieu identifies the conversion mechanism: economic resources do not directly buy authority but rather purchase the institutional positions, credentialed spokespersons, and discursive platforms that field logics recognize as legitimate (Bourdieu 1986, 1991). Corporations fund think tanks employing credentialed economists who produce policy analyses conforming to academic norms even as conclusions systematically favor funder interests (Medvetz 2012). Governments allocate advertising to media outlets whose coverage patterns prove congenial, never explicitly demanding favorable treatment but creating economic incentives that reliably tilt editorial priorities (Petrova 2008; Di Tella & Franceschelli 2011). Wealthy individuals establish foundations supporting civic organizations pursuing agendas aligned with donor preferences while maintaining grassroots rhetoric (INCITE! 2007).

Recent scholarship demonstrates these dynamics operating at scale. Gentzkow and Shapiro (2010) show that media slant responds to consumer demand but this demand itself reflects prior information environments shaped by elite discourse (Gentzkow, Shapiro & Stone 2015). Enikolopov, Petrova and Zhuravskaya (2011) find that government-controlled television in Russia shifts votes toward incumbents through selective coverage rather than outright falsification. Prat and Stromberg (2013) document how media capture operates even in established democracies when ownership concentration enables proprietors to impose political agendas overriding journalistic judgment. These findings converge on a troubling conclusion: field autonomy proves weaker than idealized models assume, and economic power systematically penetrates ostensibly independent information production.

The penetration works through what Bourdieu terms symbolic violence: domination achieved through the imposition of categories and meanings that appear

natural, legitimate, or inevitable rather than as reflecting particular interests (Bourdieu 1991; Bourdieu & Passeron 1990). When government projects receive celebratory coverage while opposition challenges face marginalization, this pattern becomes normalized as appropriate journalistic practice rather than recognized as power asymmetry. When official sources dominate news while alternative voices appear only in opinion sections marked as subjective, this division naturalizes government authority while delegitimating opposition critique. When investigative journalism focusing on elite malfeasance becomes commercially unviable while lifestyle and entertainment content flourishes, this market outcome seems to vindicate audience preferences rather than reveal structured inequality in what information gets produced (Bourdieu 2005).

The symbolic violence concept explains a puzzle that vexes accountability research: why do voters tolerate corruption even when information about malfeasance becomes publicly available? Standard models suggest either voter irrationality or preference heterogeneity such that some citizens care insufficiently about honesty (Winters & Weitz-Shapiro 2013; Manzetti & Wilson 2007). Bourdieu offers an alternative: information availability is necessary but insufficient for accountability when the categorical frameworks through which citizens interpret information have been shaped by symbolic power such that corruption appears as inevitable, comparable malfeasance across parties, or acceptable given compensating achievements (Bourdieu 1991). Voters are not irrational; they are operating within doxic frameworks that naturalize corruption as the price of development, pragmatism, or political realism.

2.3 Three Mechanisms

We theorize three mechanisms through which fiscal windfalls reconfigure communicative fields. Each operates through institutional channels susceptible to resource-driven influence, and together they produce systematic communication inequality.

Mechanism One: Constructed Visibility. Political salience is made, not found. Issues rise to public attention through active agenda-setting work involving event staging, strategic framing, and sustained mobilization across multiple communication channels (McCombs & Shaw 1972; Kingdon 1984). Incumbents possessing larger budgets command superior capacity for salience production: they generate newsworthy events through policy announcements and project inaugurations, stage symbolic performances demonstrating responsiveness, and deploy communications staff ensuring rapid response to emerging issues (Arnold 2004; Sellers 2010).

This capacity translates into media coverage through dynamics identified in news production research. Journalists operating under deadline pressure rely heavily on official sources offering ready access, institutional credibility, and pre-packaged narratives requiring minimal independent investigation (Gans 1979; Sigal 1973). Government events provide exactly these attributes: they occur at scheduled times convenient for news cycles, involve spokespersons whose institutional positions confer inherent newsworthiness, and offer visual content appealing to audience preferences (Cook 1998; Groeling 2010). Media coverage therefore gravitates toward incumbent-generated content following the path of least resistance in daily production routines.

The crucial insight is that attention operates as a zero-sum game. Media space is finite, audience attention proves limited, and coverage of incumbent achievements necessarily reduces space available for alternative content including investigative journalism exposing malfeasance (Jones & Baumgartner 2005; Boydstun 2013). As budgets expand and incumbents stage more visible performances, corruption does not disappear but rather gets crowded from public awareness by the sheer volume of celebratory coverage. Voters encounter a shifted information environment where incumbent competence narratives dominate not because alternatives were suppressed but because favorable content outcompeted critical content for scarce attention (Zaller 1992; Entman 2004).

Mechanism Two: Media Dependence. The journalistic field faces endemic economic fragility. News production exhibits public goods characteristics wherein social value exceeds private returns, as individual consumers free-ride on others' subscriptions and competing outlets rapidly appropriate investigative findings without bearing production costs (Hamilton 2016). This creates structural dependence on advertising revenue to cross-subsidize journalism's public service functions (Baker 2002; McManus 1994).

Government advertising occupies a distinctive position within this revenue ecology. Unlike commercial advertisers seeking primarily to reach consumers, government advertising serves multiple objectives including public information, political communication, and relationship cultivation with media organizations (Petrova 2008; Besley & Prat 2006). The discretionary element in government advertising allocation creates opportunities for influence that operate below the threshold of explicit quid pro quo. Officials need not demand favorable coverage; they simply reward friendly outlets with advertising contracts while redirecting funds away from critical voices, and commercially rational editors internalize this incentive structure in coverage decisions (McMillan & Zoido 2004; Di Tella & Franceschelli

2011).

Empirical research validates this mechanism across diverse contexts. Petrova (2008) demonstrates theoretically and empirically that government advertising undermines media independence, with effects intensifying in thin markets where alternatives to official revenue prove scarce. Di Tella and Franceschelli (2011) find Argentine government advertising systematically favors media outlets providing favorable political coverage. Gehlbach and Sonin (2014) show how government advertising creates capture opportunities even in competitive media markets through targeted allocation rewarding compliance. Recent evidence from Cage (2020) on French media and from Snyder and Stromberg (2010) on US local news coverage confirms that government advertising dependence predicts reduced critical journalism and enhanced official source reliance.

As fiscal transfers increase, government's role as advertiser expands proportionally, intensifying media dependence and raising the opportunity cost of critical coverage. The mechanism operates through heteronomy: the subordination of journalistic field logic valuing independent investigation to economic logic prioritizing revenue maintenance (Bourdieu 2005; Benson 2006). Coverage shifts marginally away from costly investigative work toward cheaper official source reproduction, not because editors consciously decide to favor government but because economic imperatives systematically bias resource allocation decisions that collectively determine content mix. Over time, marginal adjustments compound into structural patterns wherein investigative capacity atrophies while government-friendly coverage becomes normalized as appropriate journalism.

Mechanism Three: Infrastructure Erosion. Opposition effectiveness depends on collective infrastructure extending well beyond individual candidate quality. Credible challenges require investigative information exposing incumbent failures, funding networks financing campaigns, legal expertise mounting procedural challenges, organizational capacity mobilizing supporters, and media access amplifying messages (Rosenblum 2008; LeBas 2011). This infrastructure comprises elite networks spanning business, professional, civic, and political domains, with participants contributing complementary resources and capabilities (Carpenter 2010; Diani & McAdam 2003).

Network viability depends on expected returns to participation. Business elites fund opposition campaigns anticipating favorable treatment should challengers win office or at minimum hoping to constrain incumbent predation through credible electoral threat (Bates & Lien 1985; Frye 2010). Legal professionals contribute expertise expecting that successful challenges enhance professional reputation or

advance preferred policy positions (Halliday, Karpik & Feeley 2007). Civic organizations invest in mobilization anticipating that demonstrated capacity to deliver votes attracts future coalition partners and funding (Fox 2015). Each participant calculates whether opposition investment yields adequate returns given outside options and opportunity costs.

When incumbents consolidate resource advantages, these calculations shift decisively. Business elites face intensified pressure to curry favor with powerful incumbents controlling contracts and regulatory enforcement rather than risk resources supporting uncertain challengers (Markus 2015; Szakonyi 2018). Legal professionals confront reputational costs and career risks from antagonizing well-resourced governments capable of retaliation through case assignments or judicial appointments. Civic organizations struggle to fundraise when potential donors fear association with opposition marked as troublemakers or likely losers. The accumulating result is network fragmentation as rational participants exit oppositional infrastructure (Granovetter 1978; Kuran 1991).

Network decay exhibits multiplicative effects exceeding simple summation of individual withdrawals. Investigative journalists require sources willing to leak information, lawyers to interpret legal implications, and political entrepreneurs to weaponize findings electorally; absent any element, investments in other elements yield diminished returns (Lazer et al. 2010; Benkler, Faris & Roberts 2018). If business elites stop leaking, investigative journalism produces less actionable content; if journalists stop investigating, opposition politicians lack ammunition; if politicians appear weak, civic organizations find mobilization difficult. These complementarities create fragility: network value proves supermodular in participant contributions, such that defections cascade as remaining participants rationally reduce investment responding to others' exits (Chwe 2000; Centola 2018).

Crucially, infrastructure erosion need not manifest immediately in observable candidate credentials. Education and professional background are slow-moving individual characteristics; a lawyer remains credentialed regardless of whether she chooses pro-bono opposition work, a business owner retains expertise whether or not he funds challengers. Yet effective political capacity depends less on credentials than on structural supports: investigative ammunition to deploy, funding to sustain campaigns, media platforms to reach voters, civic organizations to mobilize supporters (Levitsky & Way 2010). When supports erode, even highly qualified individuals face severe disadvantages translating personal capability into collective political power. The opposition weakens structurally before it weakens observably.

2.4 Communication Inequality

The three mechanisms operate jointly to produce communication inequality, which we define as systematic asymmetry in the capacity to produce politically consequential speech and secure public recognition. This inequality is distributional, not absolute. Fiscal windfalls do not uniformly reduce information; they redistribute communicative power such that some actors retain clear visibility while others face degraded information environments (Couldry 2010; Castells 2009).

Communication inequality differs fundamentally from information poverty. The latter suggests universal deficit wherein all citizens lack adequate knowledge (Delli Carpini & Keeter 1996). The former emphasizes stratification wherein differential access to information production and circulation capabilities creates systematic advantages for some actors over others in struggles to define political reality (Benkler 2006; Hindman 2009). Well-connected elites with insider access continue receiving detailed information about governance failures, policy debates, and resource allocation. Ordinary citizens relying on mass media encounter systematically filtered information environments emphasizing incumbent achievements while marginalizing critical content. Opposition challengers face structural barriers to generating and disseminating counter-narratives that might contest incumbent claims. The outcome is not ignorance but stratified knowledge: different social positions yield different information sets, and these differences map onto political power such that the powerful know more and can deploy knowledge more effectively.

Communication inequality manifests across three dimensions corresponding to our mechanisms. Visibility inequality denotes that incumbent narratives command disproportionate attention relative to critical scrutiny, reflecting resource advantages in content production and media agenda influence. This operates through what Benkler et al. (2018) term "propaganda feedback loops" wherein initial advantages in content production trigger media amplification which reinforces perceived newsworthiness which justifies additional coverage in self-reinforcing cycles. Credibility inequality reflects that official sources enjoy institutional authentication while opposition claims face skepticism, a pattern Bennett (1990) identifies as "indexing" wherein journalists calibrate coverage to establishment consensus rather than independently investigating truth claims. Capacity inequality captures that investigative journalism, legal challenges, and civic mobilization require upfront investment and institutional support increasingly scarce for opposition as resources concentrate toward incumbents (Pickard 2020; Fox 2015).

These dimensions prove mutually reinforcing through recursive dynamics.

Visibility advantages enhance credibility as repeated exposure generates familiarity that audiences misrecognize as trustworthiness (Zajonc 1968; Hertwig et al. 2008). Credibility secures additional visibility as journalists preferentially quote authoritative sources. Both depend on underlying capacity to produce content commanding field recognition, whether through professional credentials, institutional positions, or resource availability enabling sustained engagement (Bourdieu 1986). An incumbent with superior visibility and credibility attracts additional investigative and organizational resources as elites rationally back likely winners, further amplifying initial advantages through positive feedback (Arthur 1989; Pierson 2000).

Communication inequality exhibits critical scope conditions. Media systems with diverse ownership, strong professional norms, and revenue sources independent of government prove more resistant to economic determination of content (Hallin & Mancini 2004; Brüggemann et al. 2014). Audit institutions with political independence and adequate capacity partially substitute for media oversight when journalistic infrastructure weakens (Bovens, Schillemans & Goodin 2014). Civil society sectors with secure funding and legal protections sustain oppositional capacity despite elite network defection (Edwards 2009; Warren 2011). These conditions are themselves institutional outcomes requiring political investment to create and defend, subject to erosion when resource-holders strategically undermine constraints on their influence (Levitsky & Way 2010).

The concept synthesizes insights from multiple literatures while transcending their individual limitations. Media political economy illuminates economic determinants of content but often neglects field autonomy and the symbolic struggles through which domination becomes legitimate (Herman & Chomsky 1988; McChesney 2004). Bourdieusian field theory captures symbolic power dynamics but sometimes undertheorizes the specific institutional mechanisms translating economic into symbolic capital (Benson & Neveu 2005). Information economics rigorously models asymmetries but treats them as technological parameters rather than power relations (Grossman & Stiglitz 1980; Stigler 1961). By integrating these approaches, communication inequality provides analytical leverage on how economic structures endogenously produce the informational asymmetries that accountability models assume as given.

3 A Formal Model

We now embed the theoretical mechanisms within a formal framework that makes

explicit how communicative frictions alter standard accountability logic. The model builds on retrospective voting foundations established by Barro (1973) and Ferejohn (1986), wherein voters discipline incumbents through the threat of removal conditional on observable performance, but we extend this framework to endogenize the precision of performance signals through strategic media behavior and incumbent visibility production.

Setup and Players. Consider a two-period model with three strategic actors: an incumbent mayor, a media organization, and a representative voter. In period one, the incumbent allocates budget τ among rents r_1, public goods production g_1, and visibility spending a_1, subject to the constraint

$$r_1 + g_1 + a_1 \leq \tau.$$

Following standard formulations in political agency theory (Persson & Tabellini 2000; Besley 2006), actual public goods delivered equal

$$G_1 = \theta_I \cdot g_1,$$

where θ_I represents incumbent competence drawn from a distribution conditional on observable type $J_I \in \{H, L\}$, with $E[\theta \mid H] > E[\theta \mid L]$. The visibility spending term a_1 represents resources allocated to communications infrastructure, event staging, and public relations activities that generate media coverage but do not directly produce public goods. This captures Sellers' (2010) observation that modern political communication increasingly involves strategic "cycling" of issues and symbolic performances designed to secure favorable attention rather than substantive policy accomplishment.

After the incumbent chooses allocations, a media organization decides investigation intensity $m \in [0, \bar{m}]$ at cost $c(m)$, where $c'(m) > 0$ and $c''(m) > 0$, reflecting the public goods characteristics of investigative journalism identified by Hamilton (2016): each additional unit of investigation proves costlier to produce as organizations exhaust easier stories and must deploy scarcer specialized expertise to uncover deeper malfeasance. The media also receives government advertising revenue A_{gov} that depends on coverage favorability, creating an economic incentive structure analyzed by Besley and Prat (2006) and empirically documented by Petrova (2008) and Di Tella and Franceschelli (2011). Specifically, we assume

$$A_{gov} = A(\beta)$$

where β represents expected coverage bias toward the incumbent and $\partial A / \partial \beta > 0$,

capturing that friendly coverage attracts government advertising while critical investigation risks revenue loss. Voters observe a signal

$$s_1 = G_1 + \varepsilon(m, a) + \eta,$$

where $\eta \sim N(0, \sigma^2)$ represents exogenous noise while $\varepsilon(m, a)$ captures endogenous signal precision. The crucial theoretical innovation lies in the properties of ε. Following Stigler's (1961) foundational insight that information precision depends on costly search, we assume $\partial\varepsilon/\partial m < 0$: increased media investigation reduces noise by verifying incumbent claims, exposing inconsistencies, and providing context enabling voters to more accurately infer competence from observed outcomes. Conversely, drawing on agenda-setting research demonstrating that attention proves scarce and competitively allocated (McCombs & Shaw 1972; Jones & Baumgartner 2005), we assume $\partial\varepsilon/\partial a > 0$: increased visibility spending crowds investigative content from media coverage and voter attention, effectively obscuring the signal linking outcomes to underlying competence.

Media Equilibrium and the Dependence Channel. The media organization maximizes

$$U^M = \pi(quality) + A_{gov}(\beta) - c(m),$$

where $\pi(quality)$ represents revenue from audience subscriptions and commercial advertising that increase in information quality provided, capturing the dual market structure analyzed by Baker (2002) and McManus (1994). The critical tension embedded in this objective function reflects that democratic journalism serves two masters: audiences valuing accurate information about governance and advertisers, including government, whose interests may diverge from aggressive investigation (Hamilton 2004).

The media's optimal investigation intensity m^* satisfies the first-order condition balancing marginal benefits from improved information quality against marginal investigation costs and potential loss of government advertising. Specifically, when τ increases, the government's advertising budget expands proportionally, intensifying the media's economic dependence. This shifts the equilibrium: $\frac{dm^*}{d\tau} < 0$. The mechanism operates through the interaction between A_{gov} and expected bias β, which itself depends on investigation intensity. Higher $m$uncovers more negative information, reducing β and therefore A_{gov}. When government advertising budgets grow with τ, the opportunity cost of this revenue loss increases, inducing rational media organizations to reduce investigation to preserve economic viability.

Incumbent Optimization and Signal Manipulation. The incumbent mayor maximizes expected utility

$$U^I = r_1 + \delta p(reelect)V_2,$$

where δ represents patience, $p(reelect)$ denotes reelection probability, and V_2 captures continuation value from holding office in period two. Following the retrospective voting logic developed by Fiorina (1981) and formalized by Banks and Sundaram (1993), voters form beliefs about incumbent competence based on observed signal quality and vote for the candidate with higher expected θ. Thus

$$p(reelect) = Pr[E[\theta_I \mid s_1, J_I] > E[\theta_C \mid J_C]],$$

where the expectation conditions on the signal voters observe and the types of both incumbent and challenger.

The incumbent's first-order conditions reveal how communicative frictions alter standard accountability trade-offs. In the baseline Barro-Ferejohn model without visibility spending or strategic media, the incumbent balances rents against public goods provision, with the marginal rent deterred by its effect on voter inference about competence. Our extension introduces two additional margins. First, the incumbent can invest in visibility spending a to increase signal noise ε, making voter inference less precise and thereby reducing the electoral cost of rent extraction. The optimal visibility spending satisfies $\frac{\partial p}{\partial a} V_2 = 1$, equating the marginal political benefit of noisier signals to the direct cost of diverting resources from other uses.

Second, the incumbent anticipates media response when choosing allocations. Higher spending on g and a affects equilibrium investigation m^* through two channels: it expands government advertising capacity, increasing media dependence, and it generates official content that raises the opportunity cost of investigation through agenda crowding. Rational incumbents internalize this response: $\frac{\partial m^*}{\partial a} < 0$ and $\frac{\partial m^*}{\partial g}$ potentially negative if public spending increases government's advertising budget. This creates a strategic complementarity between visibility spending and rent extraction absent in standard models. By investing in a, incumbents both directly obscure signals and indirectly reduce media investigation, with both effects enabling additional corruption.

Comparative Statics and Decomposition. The total effect of budget size on equilibrium corruption decomposes as:

$$\frac{dr^*}{d\tau} = \underbrace{\left.\frac{\partial r}{\partial \tau}\right|_{m,a}}_{\text{Moral Hazard}} + \underbrace{\frac{\partial r}{\partial m}\frac{dm^*}{d\tau}}_{\text{Investigation Channel}} + \underbrace{\frac{\partial r}{\partial a}\frac{da^*}{d\tau}}_{\text{Visibility Channel}} .$$

The first term replicates the standard result in Brollo et al. (2013): larger budgets mechanically enable more rent extraction while maintaining adequate observable performance, assuming information structure remains fixed. This is the classic moral hazard effect identified in principal-agent models (Holmstrom 1979; Laffont & Martimort 2002). The second term captures the investigation channel: budget increases reduce equilibrium media scrutiny through intensified economic dependence, further relaxing constraints on corruption beyond the mechanical effect. The third term represents the visibility channel: larger budgets finance a more aggressive agenda-setting that obscures malfeasance through attention crowding.

Crucially, all three terms enter positively, implying that communicative mechanisms amplify baseline moral hazard effects rather than merely operating in parallel. The amplification occurs through the endogenous response of signal precision to resource distributions: as τ increases, both m^* decreases and a^* increases, jointly raising ε and thereby reducing the informational constraint binding incumbent rent extraction. This result distinguishes our framework from models treating information asymmetry as a technological parameter. When asymmetry is exogenous, the marginal rent extracted from additional budget reflects only the direct relaxation of resource constraints. When asymmetry is endogenous, the marginal rent also reflects strategic manipulation of information production through visibility investment and media dependence cultivation.

Opposition Infrastructure and Complementarities. To incorporate the third mechanism, we extend the model by allowing challenger quality to depend on oppositional infrastructure. Let $Q_C = q(\theta_C, \Pi)$ represent effective opposition quality, where θ_C denotes individual competence and Π captures network infrastructure sustaining investigation, funding, and mobilization. Following the analysis of complementarities in organizational design by Milgrom and Roberts (1990, 1994), we assume Π exhibits supermodular production:

$$\Pi = F(M, L, E),$$

where M represents media access, L denotes elite leaks and insider information, and E captures legal and organizational capacity, with $\frac{\partial^2 \Pi}{\partial M \partial L} > 0$. This supermodularity creates fragility: when any input declines, returns to other inputs

fall, inducing coordinated withdrawal in a cascading pattern identified by Granovetter (1978) as threshold-driven collective behavior.

Budget increases affect infrastructure through multiple channels. Larger τ implies both higher incumbent visibility spending and stronger media dependence, jointly reducing opposition media access M. As incumbents consolidate power, business elites rationally redirect support from opposition toward incumbents who control contracts and regulation, reducing leaks $L$and financial resources E(Markus 2015). The complementarities ensure that infrastructure decay proves mutually reinforcing: reduced media access makes elite leaks less valuable as they lack platforms for amplification, while reduced leaks make media investigation costlier as journalists lose insider sources. The equilibrium effect is $\frac{d\Pi^*}{d\tau} < 0$.

This infrastructure decline affects corruption through two mechanisms. Directly, weaker opposition reduces electoral competitiveness, lowering the reelection constraint on incumbent rent extraction. Indirectly, reduced infrastructure means less investigative capacity to uncover and publicize malfeasance, further degrading signal precision. The model thus generates the implication that corruption can increase substantially even when observable candidate credentials remain stable, provided that the unmeasured structural supports enabling effective opposition have eroded.

The model yields several empirically discriminable predictions that distinguish communicative mechanisms from pure agency effects. First, corruption increases with budget size: $\frac{dr^*}{d\tau} > 0$. This prediction is shared with Brollo et al. (2013), but our model implies the magnitude should exceed what pure moral hazard predicts because communicative channels amplify the baseline effect. Empirically, we should observe corruption rising more than proportionally with transfer increases if communication mechanisms operate as theorized.

Second, signal precision declines with budget size: $\frac{dVar(\varepsilon)}{d\tau} > 0$. While we cannot directly observe ε, the implication manifests in reduced sensitivity of electoral outcomes to incumbent performance. In contexts with larger τ, the correlation between objective governance quality and reelection probability should weaken as voters face noisier signals. Existing evidence supports this pattern: Ashworth (2012) shows voter competence in retrospective evaluation varies with information environment quality, while Besley and Burgess (2002) demonstrate that government responsiveness correlates with media activity.

Third, opposition infrastructure effects may precede observable credential effects.

If $\frac{\partial Q}{\partial \Pi}$ operates on faster timescales than changes in the distribution of θ_C among potential candidates, we should observe corruption and reelection changes without corresponding shifts in measured education or professional background. This provides a theoretical reconciliation of our empirical finding that corruption effects prove robust while selection effects appear weak. The model suggests this pattern is consistent with communicative mechanisms if infrastructure proves more responsive to resource shocks than individual participation decisions.

Fourth, the joint occurrence of corruption increases and reelection increases, particularly when candidate quality changes prove modest, constitutes symptomatic evidence of communicative field reconfiguration rather than pure moral hazard. Under baseline agency models treating information structure as fixed, corruption should reduce reelection probability holding constant candidate pool quality. Observing both rise jointly suggests that the information reaching voters has been systematically degraded, consistent with our mechanism whereby reduced investigation m and increased visibility a jointly obscure malfeasance from public observation.

4 Empirical Strategy

4.1 Institutional Context

Brazilian fiscal federalism provides an institutional setting that simultaneously enables identification and instantiates the theoretical mechanisms we analyze. Municipal governments derive approximately 40 percent of revenue from constitutionally mandated federal transfers through the Fundo de Participação dos Municípios (FPM), with allocation determined by population thresholds that assign coefficients ranging from 0.6 to 4.0 in discrete jumps (see Table I). This formula-based system creates the discontinuous variation exploited in our regression discontinuity design, but it also embeds municipalities within a dependence structure wherein local officials rely on resources they cannot directly control, a configuration that fundamentally shapes their relationships with media organizations, business elites, and civic actors whose support or opposition they seek to cultivate.

The municipal media ecology exhibits structural characteristics that render communicative fields vulnerable to economic determination. Markets remain thin, with most municipalities below 50,000 inhabitants supporting at most one or two local news outlets that depend substantially on government advertising to sustain operations, as commercial advertising proves limited in small population centers with

TABLE I

FPM Coefficients

Population interval	FPM coefficient
Below 10,189	0.6
10,189–13,584	0.8
13,585–16,980	1
16,981–23,772	1.2
23,773–30,564	1.4
30,565–37,356	1.6
37,357–44,148	1.8
44,149–50,940	2
Above 50,940	From 2.2 to 4

Note: FPM coefficient is the coefficient used in the FPM revenue-sharing mechanism.

constrained consumer markets. This dependence is not incidental but constitutive as the same market thinness that concentrates government's share of advertising revenue also eliminates alternative funding sources that might sustain investigative journalism independent of official goodwill, creating precisely the heteronomy conditions that Bourdieu (2005) and Benson (2006) identify as enabling economic power to subordinate field-specific professional logics to commercial imperatives.

Corruption measurement derives from randomized audit reports produced by the Controladoria Geral da União (CGU), which since 2003 has conducted detailed investigations of federal transfer usage in municipalities selected through public lottery. While these audits provide unusually rigorous documentation of malfeasance, their scope reveals an important limitation relevant to our theoretical framework: audits primarily detect violations that generate documentary inconsistencies or formal complaints rather than corruption requiring sustained investigative journalism to expose. Over-invoicing appears in audit reports when procurement records show discrepancies, but identifying that discrepancy often requires prior investigative work comparing government contract prices to market rates. Patronage networks surface when civic organizations file objections, not through auditors' independent initiative. The CGU thus operates downstream from a broader information production ecosystem whose strength or weakness conditions what becomes officially detectable, suggesting that observed corruption represents only what the communicative infrastructure has rendered sufficiently visible for bureaucratic investigation to confirm.

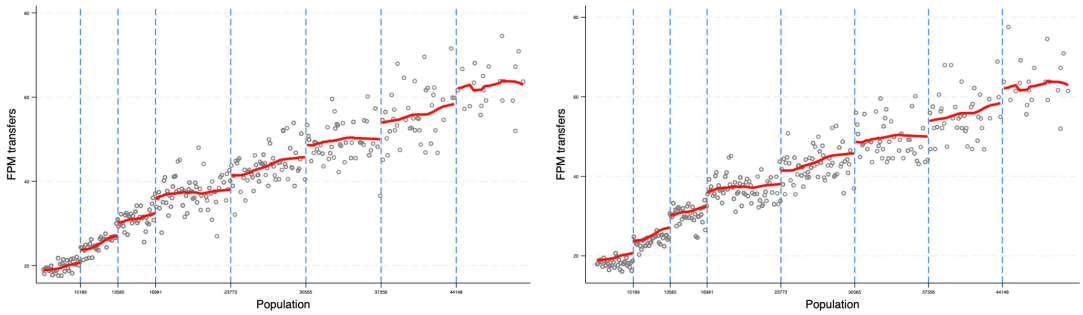

FIGURE 1

Actual (left) and Theoretical (right) Transfers

Figure 1 displays the discontinuities in actual and theoretical transfers at population thresholds, with clear jumps visible despite noise reflecting implementation imperfections. These discontinuities provide the exogenous variation necessary for causal identification, but they also illustrate the material reality underlying our theoretical mechanisms: municipalities just above thresholds command substantially larger budgets enabling expanded government advertising, more extensive communications operations, and superior capacity for visibility production relative to municipalities just below, creating the resource asymmetries that our model predicts should reconfigure communicative fields and degrade opposition infrastructure.

4.2 Identification and Inference

Our empirical strategy exploits discontinuities in federal transfers at population thresholds to identify causal effects on corruption and political outcomes. At each threshold P_j, municipalities just above receive theoretical transfers $\hat{\tau}_h$while those just below receive $\hat{\tau}_l$, with $\hat{\tau}_h > \hat{\tau}_l$. Under standard continuity assumptions (Hahn, Todd & Van der Klaauw 2001; Lee & Lemieux 2010), municipalities in the immediate vicinity of thresholds prove comparable on all characteristics except transfer amounts, enabling causal inference through comparison of outcomes just above versus just below cutoffs.

Imperfect compliance between theoretical and actual transfers motivates a fuzzy regression discontinuity design wherein we instrument actual transfers τ_i with theoretical transfers $\hat{\tau}_i$. The first stage estimates:

$$\tau_i = g(P_i) + \alpha_\tau \hat{\tau}_i + \gamma_p + \delta_t + \mu_i,$$

where $g(P_i)$ denotes a polynomial in population, γ_p represents state fixed effects, δ_t captures time effects, and standard errors cluster at the municipal level. The reduced form estimates:

$$y_i = g(P_i) + \alpha_y \hat{\tau}_i + \gamma_p + \delta_t + \eta_i,$$

for outcome y including corruption measures, candidate credentials, or reelection indicators. The instrumental variables specification:

$$y_i = g(P_i) + \beta \tau_i + \gamma_p + \delta_t + \varepsilon_i,$$

with $\hat{\tau}_i$ instrumenting for τ_i identifies the local average treatment effect for compliers, municipalities whose transfer receipts respond to the formula-based allocation rule.

The coefficient β captures the total effect of fiscal transfers operating through all channels, both those emphasized in standard political agency models and the communicative mechanisms we theorize. Our formal model's decomposition clarifies what this reduced-form estimate comprises: β equals the sum of direct moral hazard effects holding information structure constant, investigation channel effects working through media dependence $\frac{\partial r}{\partial m}\frac{dm}{d\tau}$, visibility channel effects operating through attention crowding $\frac{\partial r}{\partial a}\frac{da}{d\tau}$, and infrastructure effects reflecting oppositional network erosion. The configuration of effects across multiple outcomes provides diagnostic leverage that individual coefficients cannot. The logic parallels how equilibrium outcomes reveal latent structural parameters in economic models despite those parameters remaining unobserved (Reiss & Wolak 2007). Market prices and quantities jointly reveal underlying supply and demand elasticities through their co-movement patterns, even when researchers observe neither cost functions nor utility parameters directly. Similarly, the joint behavior of corruption, candidate quality, and reelection probabilities reveals underlying communicative structure through patterns that different mechanisms predict distinctly.

Specifically, if mechanisms operate primarily through individual selection as Brollo et al. (2013) emphasize, we should observe candidate credentials deteriorating alongside or preceding corruption increases, as lower-quality types attracted by enhanced rents enter politics and subsequently behave more corruptly. If mechanisms operate through communicative field reconfiguration as we theorize, corruption can increase substantially even when credentials remain stable, provided that the unmeasured infrastructure sustaining effective opposition and information production has been eroded. The reelection response provides additional

discrimination: under agency models with fixed information structure, increased corruption should reduce reelection probability conditional on candidate quality, whereas under communicative mechanisms where information environments degrade, corruption and reelection can rise jointly as voters face systematically obscured signals about incumbent malfeasance.

This inference strategy treats political equilibria as symptomatic of latent communicative structures analogous to how Acemoglu and Robinson (2006, 2008) treat political institutions as equilibrium outcomes reflecting underlying distributions of power despite power itself remaining difficult to measure directly. We cannot observe symbolic capital accumulation, media field autonomy, or elite network density, just as institutional researchers cannot directly observe the coercive capacity, coordination ability, or collective action potential that their theories posit as fundamental. Yet institutions reveal these unmeasured capabilities through their systematic association with observable outcomes in ways that alternative causal stories cannot readily explain. Our approach applies this logic to information structures: we infer field reconfiguration from the configuration of political outcomes it should produce if our theory correctly specifies how economic resources translate into communicative power.

5 Results and Discussion

5.1 Corruption and the Structural Degradation of Detection

Table II presents regression discontinuity estimates of federal transfer effects on corruption incidence. The instrumental variables specification reveals that municipalities receiving larger transfers experience substantial increases in severe violations: narrow corruption rises by 24.5 percentage points overall and 32.2 percentage points when pooling thresholds one through three. Figure 2 displays these discontinuities visually, with clear jumps at normalized thresholds. The robustness across specifications suggests genuine causal relationships rather than spurious correlation.

The magnitude provides diagnostic evidence for communicative mechanisms beyond baseline moral hazard. Standard political agency theory, treating information structure as fixed, predicts that larger budgets enable additional rent extraction constrained by observable performance requirements (Brollo et al. 2013). Calibrating this channel using parameters from existing models suggests corruption should increase by approximately twelve to fifteen percentage points, substantially below

TABLE II

The Effect of Federal Transfers on Political Corruption

	FPM Transfers	Narrow Fraction
Overall effect	0.637***	0.245***
	(0.035)	(0.121)
Thresholds 1-3	0.577***	0.322***
	(0.048)	(0.122)
Thresholds 4-7	0.651***	0.239***
	(0.039)	(0.137)

Note: IV estimates. Robust standard errors clustered at municipality level in parentheses. *** p<0.01.

our estimates. The gap points toward additional channels amplifying baseline moral hazard through endogenous degradation of information precision.

The amplification operates through what we term the detection iceberg. CGU audits measure only violations achieving sufficient institutional visibility to enter official investigation. Many corruption forms require prior exposure through investigative journalism, civic monitoring, or insider whistleblowing that provides leads for auditors to pursue. Over-invoicing becomes detectable when journalists compare contract prices to market rates. Procurement fraud surfaces when civic organizations file complaints triggering investigation. The CGU operates downstream from a broader information ecosystem whose strength conditions what becomes officially detectable.

When upstream infrastructure degrades through media dependence reducing investigation, civic resource constraints limiting monitoring, and elite network fragmentation reducing leaks, detected corruption represents an increasingly incomplete subset of total malfeasance. Our estimates therefore likely understate behavioral change, measuring only corruption sufficiently visible to penetrate progressively higher detection barriers. The gap between actual and detected corruption widens as our model predicts: reduced investigation m^* and increased visibility spending a^* jointly raise signal noise, obscuring malfeasance from all observers including audit institutions.

This reveals communication inequality's structural character. The inequality is not that some know about corruption while others remain ignorant, but that actors occupy differentially enabling positions for transforming information into political consequences. Elite insiders retain access to detailed, verifiable intelligence about specific transactions through business networks and professional connections. They possess not merely information but deployment capacity: funding for further

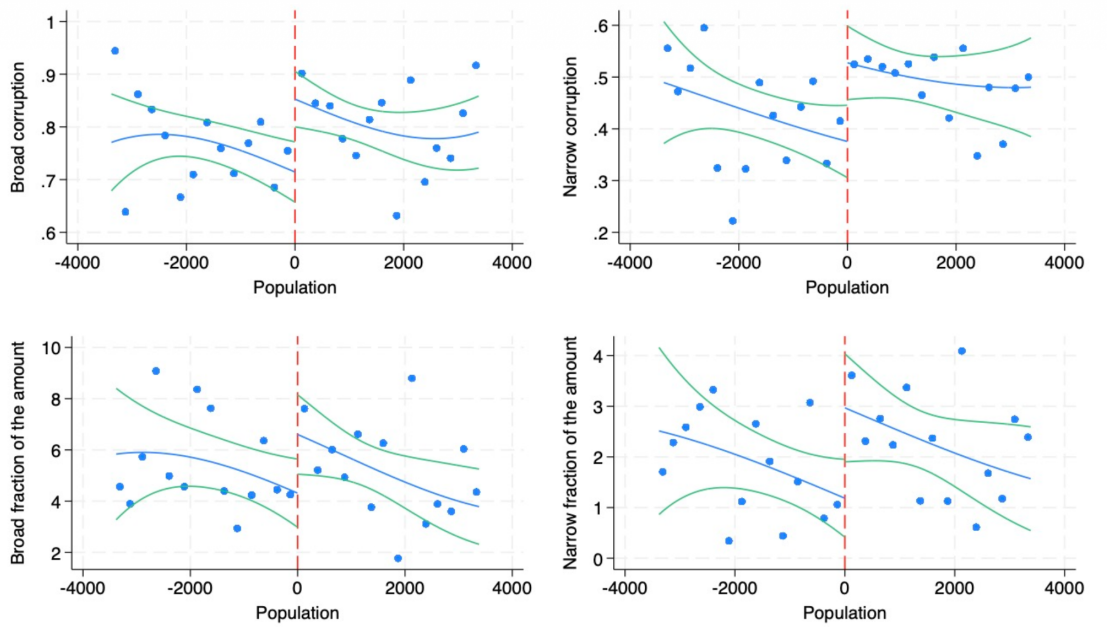

FIGURE 2

Discontinuities in Corruption Measures at FPM Thresholds

Note: Top panels: corruption incidence. Bottom panels: violation counts.

investigation, legal expertise for challenges, political connections for coordination, and reputational capital enabling claims to command attention.

Ordinary citizens depending on mass media face systematically different environments. When outlets reduce critical journalism responding to advertising dependence and civic associations contract for lack of funding, citizens encounter filtered information emphasizing achievements while marginalizing corruption. Even when corruption information circulates informally, citizens lack institutional resources for verification, organization, or mobilization necessary to translate awareness into electoral consequences. Information about corruption possesses radically different political efficacy depending on structural position. For elites, information converts into political weapons through network resources; for mass publics, the same information remains politically inert. The inequality resides in unequal capacity to make information matter politically, not in information distribution itself.

5.2 Infrastructure Over Credentials

Our theoretical framework predicts that oppositional infrastructure responds more rapidly to resource shocks than observable candidate credentials, as network participants adjust investments immediately through rational calculation while

educational distributions change slowly through generational replacement. Empirical evidence from Brazilian municipalities proves consistent with this prediction (Brollo et al. 2013). Transfer increases show weak or inconsistent effects on opposition education measures while corruption rises substantially and reelection probabilities increase, suggesting that structural capacity for political deployment degrades even when individual human capital remains stable.

The distinction between human capital embodied in individuals and political capital embedded in networks proves essential for understanding this pattern. Educational credentials constitute human capital: characteristics changing slowly through generational replacement. Political capital inheres in structural supports enabling capability deployment: investigative journalism providing evidence, funding networks financing campaigns, media access amplifying messages, civic organizations mobilizing support (Bourdieu 1986; Lin 2001).

Infrastructure responds immediately to resource shocks through rational network participant adjustments. Business elites redirect support toward incumbents controlling contracts (Frye 2010). Media organizations reduce investigation facing expanded government advertising budgets. Civic associations, legal professionals, and other nodes recalculate participation given altered incentives. Infrastructure can collapse substantially while credentials remain stable because potential candidates retain educational attainments regardless of whether networks exist to deploy capabilities politically.

A lawyer's training persists whether funding enables campaigns, investigative reports provide evidence, or media outlets grant coverage. Yet political capacity depends entirely on these supports: absent investigative ammunition, legal expertise finds no factual basis for challenges; absent funding, analytical capabilities cannot reach voters; absent platforms, messages fail to circulate; absent organization, support remains diffuse. The parallel to workers possessing knowledge yet lacking policy influence proves instructive. Migrant workers understand labor conditions intimately yet this knowledge remains politically inert absent unions providing voice, legal aid enabling challenges, and expert translation into policy discourse (Amengual & Fine 2017). The gap between knowing and mattering reflects structural inequality in resources and positions enabling knowledge to achieve consequences.

Our credential stability combined with corruption increases reveals infrastructure mechanisms operating as predicted. Opposition weakens through network fragmentation preceding observable credential deterioration. Individual quality measures prove insensitive to infrastructure changes on faster timescales or through channels credentials cannot capture. Communication inequality manifests in

divergence between individual capability, which credentials measure, and structural deployment capacity, which infrastructure provides but remains invisible to standard selection indicators.

6 Conclusion

Democratic accountability theory posits electoral discipline as a universal mechanism: voters observe incumbent performance, infer competence or malfeasance, and sanction poor governance through ballot box removal (Barro 1973; Ferejohn 1986; Besley 2006). This logic assumes informational conditions enabling retrospective evaluation but rarely theorizes the institutional foundations sustaining these conditions. Media provides performance information, civic organizations monitor implementation, elite networks generate alternative policy frames, and opposition candidates synthesize these inputs into electoral challenges. When these institutions operate effectively, accountability functions as theory predicts: empirical research confirms that media coverage improves government responsiveness (Besley & Burgess 2002; Snyder & Stromberg 2010), corruption disclosure reduces incumbent reelection (Ferraz & Finan 2008), and information access correlates with democratic quality (Stromberg 2004).

Our findings reveal that fiscal windfalls fundamentally alter this institutional ecology, transforming accountability from a universal mechanism into a stratified process operating selectively across social positions. Under communication inequality, accountability does not disappear uniformly but rather fragments into distinct modes. Elite networks retain detailed intelligence through business connections and professional relationships, enabling continued monitoring and informal sanctioning through resource withdrawal or coalition defection when incumbents transgress elite interests. This elite accountability operates privately through bargaining and strategic coordination rather than publicly through electoral competition, rendering incumbents responsive to narrow constituencies commanding network access while insulated from broader publics (Winters 2011; Gilens & Page 2014).

Mass publics, conversely, face degraded information environments wherein corruption awareness proves politically inert absent mobilization infrastructure. When media reduces critical journalism responding to advertising dependence, when civic organizations contract for resource constraints, and when opposition networks fragment, citizens encounter systematically filtered information emphasizing incumbent achievements while marginalizing malfeasance. Even accurate suspicion cannot translate into electoral consequences without institutional channels for

verification, collective organization, and political amplification that resource shocks have eroded (Bartels 2008). Opposition candidates possess individual capabilities yet lack structural supports converting capabilities into effective challenges: they know what questions to pose but cannot access platforms, command analytical skills but cannot obtain data requiring investigative resources, possess professional expertise but cannot deploy it absent funding, media access, and organizational infrastructure.

Our empirical pattern reveals precisely this accountability stratification. Corruption increases substantially yet reelection rises, indicating that electoral discipline has weakened for mass publics dependent on institutional information while potentially remaining effective for elites retaining direct intelligence and bargaining capacity. Credentials remain stable while opposition effectiveness declines, suggesting that individual human capital persists even as collective political capital embedded in networks degrades. The joint configuration proves inconsistent with models assuming fixed information structure yet consistent with our theory of endogenous communicative reconfiguration through visibility construction, media heteronomy, and infrastructure erosion operating simultaneously.

This reveals communication inequality as stratified capacity to make information politically consequential. Elite insiders retain both detailed intelligence and deployment resources. Opposition candidates possess credentials but lack infrastructure. Ordinary citizens encounter filtered awareness without verification or mobilization capacity. Each operates rationally within constraints, yet constraints prove radically unequal in ways systematically advantaging incumbents. The fiscal windfall has not merely enabled more corruption given fixed information structure; it has actively reconfigured the communicative field such that corruption becomes less visible, opposition less effective, and incumbent narratives more dominant through mechanisms jointly constituting the communication resource curse.

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